



Deceptive Endorsements of Skincare Products: Ethical Concerns for Female Youth in Ahmedabad



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❑ INTRODUCTION

- The skincare industry has seen a significant transformation with the rise of influencer marketing (product endorsements by influencer). Influencers, often referred to as "skinfluencers," have become pivotal in shaping consumer choices, especially among the youth. These influencers, who may lack formal dermatological qualifications, often promote skincare products through social media platforms like Instagram and YouTube
- By examining the practices of skin influencers and their influence on consumer choices, we can unravel the challenges and opportunities inherent in this rapidly evolving landscape
- **OBJECTIVES OF THE STUDY:** To assess the impact of these deceptive endorsements on the purchasing decisions and trust of the target demographic.
- The main geographical location of this study is Ahmedabad, Gujarat, India

- **Industry Focus**

This research will explore how endorsements which are deceptive affects business dynamics in the industry

- **EXTENT**

This survey is done in Ahmedabad city.

- **DURATION**

We did this survey and completion of the study in period of 6 months.[1.9] **SAMPLE SIZE**We did this survey with 200 responses of female youth in Ahmedabad.

❑ LITERATURE REVIEW

Author	Journal	Review
Desai & Shah (2019)	International journal of advertising	The ethical concerns extend beyond consumer deception and include the broader impact on societal beauty standards.
Jones & Glynn (2021)	Journal of media and youth research	Several studies have shown that female youth, particularly teenagers, are vulnerable to marketing tactics that play on their insecurities about appearance.
Mr. Kapoor (2022)	Journal of Digital behaviour	Celebrity and influencer endorsements play a crucial role in shaping consumer preferences, especially among younger audiences.
Mr. Kumar (2023)	Indian journal of social Marketing	Local campaign promoting self acceptance and providing a counter narrative to the marketing of skincare products.
Madhumita & Ponnarasu (2024)	Journal of business ethics	Ethical violations in marketing practices, particularly in low- and middle-income countries, necessitate stricter regulations to protect young consumers.

❏ Methodology

Research Design:

The explanatory sequential mixed-methods study investigates the deceptive beauty endorsement and ethical issues among 200 young women in Ahmedabad. The quantitative method involves a survey, while the qualitative method involves focus groups. After separate analyses for quantitative and qualitative data, the final step is an integration for holistic interpretation.

Method of Data Collection:

1. Online Surveys:

- Time-efficient, economical, and mobile-friendly.
- Platforms include Google Forms, SurveyMonkey, Type form.
- Elements include visual designs, branching logic, and ethical considerations (informed consent, anonymity).

2. Data Analysis:

- The data from Google Forms will be exported into Excel for statistical analysis.
- Spearman's Rank Correlation: Assesses both strength and direction of a connection between two variables.
- Hypothesis test, involving null and alternative hypotheses, to examine significance of outcomes.

❑ Research Methodology Overview

Type of Research: Descriptive

Focus on awareness, perceptions, and behaviors of female youth regarding deceptive skincare endorsements through surveys.

Data Collection:

Primary Data: Surveys from 200 female youth in Ahmedabad.

Secondary Data: Collected from journals, internet sources, magazines, and textbooks.

❑ Sampling Design & Project Design

Sampling Design:

Procedure: Descriptive method with no stratification, ensuring uniform sample size.

Sample Size: 200 female youths in Ahmedabad who use skin care products and are exposed to advertisements.

Project Design:

It is a Mixed Methods: Survey will measure the exposure, buying, and values; focus group will examine understanding and emotional response.

Analysis: Integrated approach. The data combined from the use of both types of methods would be quantitative-survey and qualitative-focus groups. come a dominant force in shaping consumer preferences, especially amongst young audiences. Influencers, with their large followings, wield significant influence over purchasing decisions.

❑ Purpose of questionnaire

- Find connections between the influencers' endorsements and young women with regard to their financial and brand choices.
- Gauge awareness of dishonest promotions and the credibility of influencers in the skin care industry.- To investigate how the target audience views ethical concerns concerning skincare endorsements.
- Evaluate existing regulations in place and accountability in relation to misleading marketing practices on behalf of influencers and brands.
- Guarantees anonymity to participants and allows them time for reflection when filling their responses, lays a good area of standardization, and is cost-efficient in targeting a large audience.

❑ Questionnaire

- **How do deceptive endorsements affect the youth's perception of skincare products?**
 - a) They make youth more skeptical of all products
 - b) They encourage natural skincare practices
 - c) They create unrealistic beauty standards
 - d) They increase consumer awareness
- **From whom do you come to know about any new skincare product?**
 - a) Family
 - b) Classmates
 - c) Colleagues
 - d) Friends
 - e) Relatives
- **On which social media do you see the most endorsements of skincare products.**
 - a) YouTube
 - b) Instagram
 - c) Facebook
 - d) Telegram
- **What type of endorsement do young female consumers often trust the most?**
 - a) Celebrity endorsements
 - b) Influencer and peer recommendations
 - c) Dermatologist endorsements
 - d) Traditional media ads
- **What factors influence your decision to buy a skincare product of a particular company?**
 - a) Personal experience
 - b) Influencer's credibility
 - c) Reviews from other users
 - d) Promotional offers
- **Have you ever been deceived by any endorsement of skincare products?**
 - a) Yes
 - b) No
- **In which type of skincare product did you experience the deception?**
 - a) Whitening cream
 - b) Face pack
 - c) Anti – aging cream
 - d) Dark circle cream
 - e) Others

❑ Questionnaire

- **What side effects or problems did you face?**

- a) No positive change b) Dryness c) Acne vulgaris
- d) Oily face e) Rashes/ Burnout f) Other

- **What steps did you take after experiencing above effects or problems?**

- a) Home remedy b) Consult Dermatologist c) Moving towards natural product
- d) Complain to customer support e) others

- **How much do you trust endorsements from skincare influencers?**

- a) Very trustworthy b) Somewhat trustworthy
- c) Neutral d) Not trustworthy

- **Do you believe that influencers genuinely use the products they endorse?**

- a) Yes always b) Sometimes
- c) Rarely d) Never

- **How often do you think influencers oversell benefits of skincare products?**

- a) Very often b) Sometimes
- c) Rarely d) Never

- **Have you ever felt misled by an influencer's endorsement?**

- a) Yes
- b) No

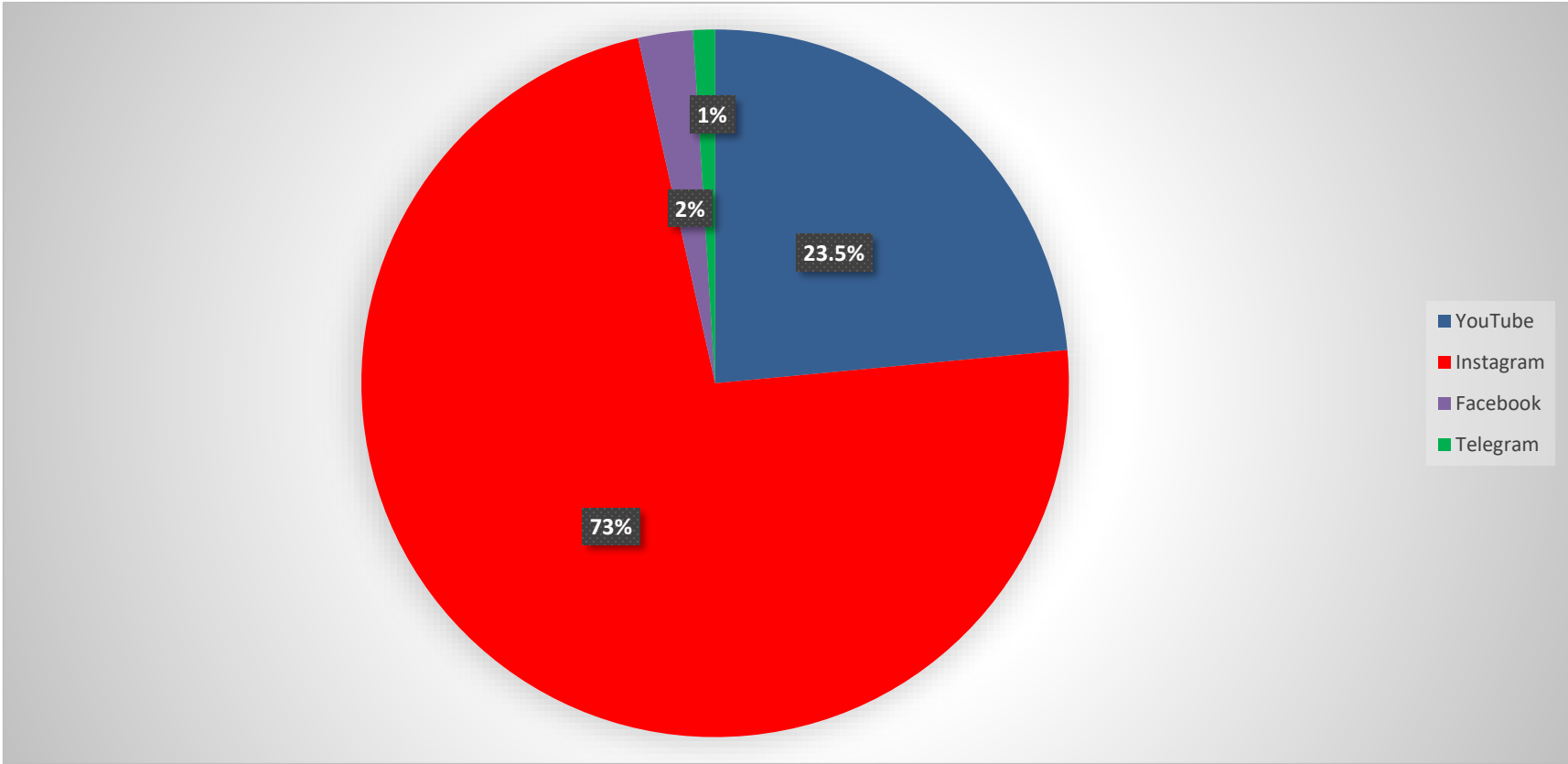
- **How concerned are you about ethical issues in influencer endorsements of a skincare product.**

- a) Very concerned b) Somewhat concerned c) Neutral d) Not Concerned

❑ Questionnaire

- **Have you ever read disclaimers or disclosure on influencer's post?**
a)Yes b)No
- **Have you ever noticed any patterns in deceptive endorsements among specific influencer demographics?**
a)Yes b)No
- **How likely are you to purchase a skincare product of a company after seeing its endorsement?**
a)Very likely b)Somewhat likely c)Neutral d)Unlikely
- **Should officials of deceptive skincare endorsements face consequences for misleading endorsements?**
a)Yes b)No c)Unsure
- **Do you think deceptive endorsements by one harm the credibility of all other endorsements?**
a)Yes b)Not necessarily c)No
- **Do you consult a dermatologist before using any skincare products?**
a)Yes b)No c)Sometimes
- **Have you experienced any of these side effects of skincare products?**
a)Rashes b)Dryness c)Burning sensation d)Excessive itching
- **Have you ever reported such side effects to the company's customer care?**
a)Yes b)No
- **Was the company's response/compensation satisfactory according to you?**
a)Fully satisfactory b)Satisfactory c)not satisfactory d) No response
- **Do you ever check the success or efficacy of the skincare products through reviews before buying it?**
a)Yes b)No c)Yes, when it is a new product concept.

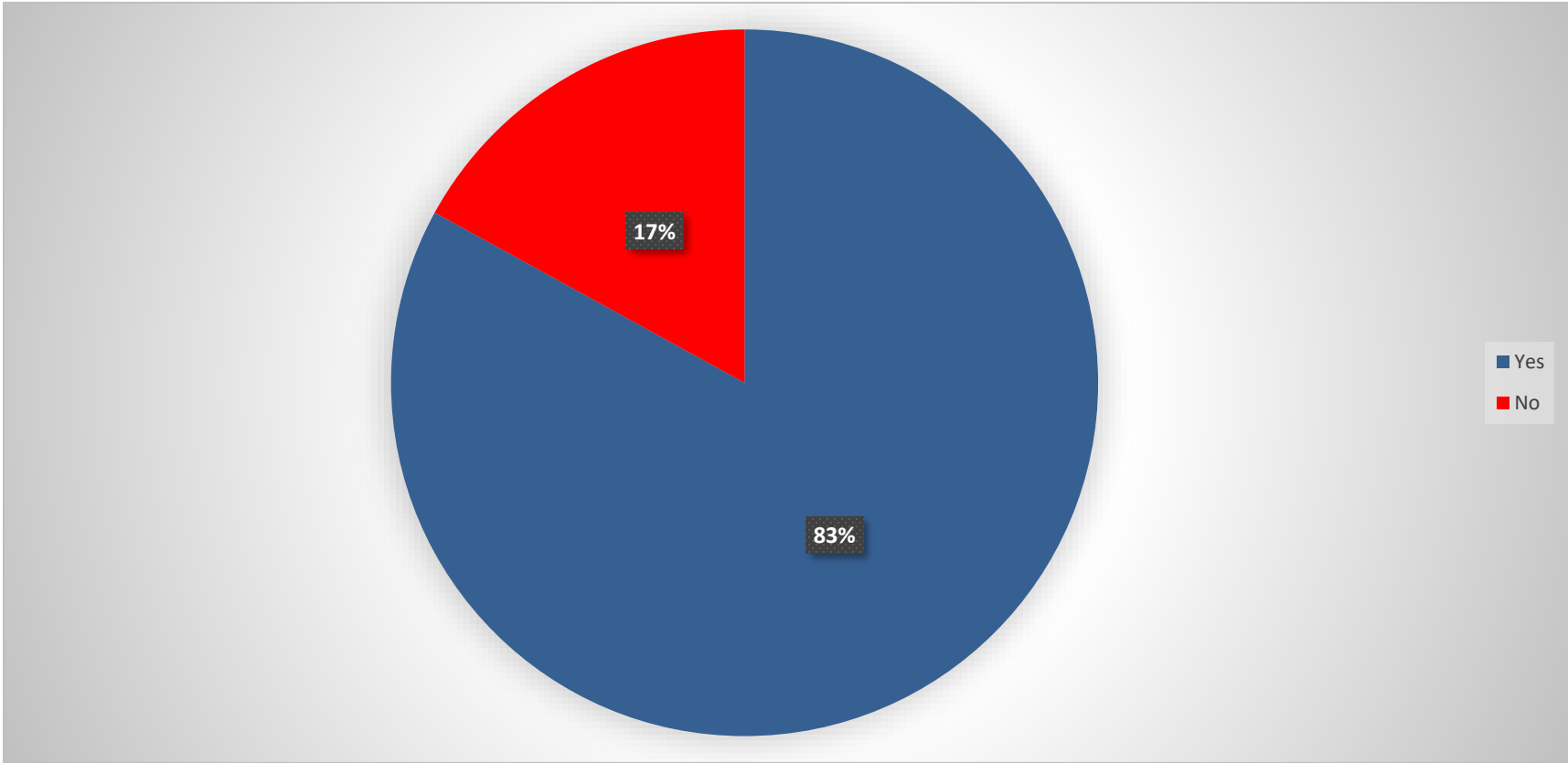
•On which social media do you see the most endorsements of skincare products.



INTERPRETATION:

Above table and chart, we can see that number of people who respond and majority of it. From analysis we interpret that they see the most endorsements of skincare products on social media from 73% from Instagram, 23.5% from YouTube, 2% from Facebook and 1% from Telegram.

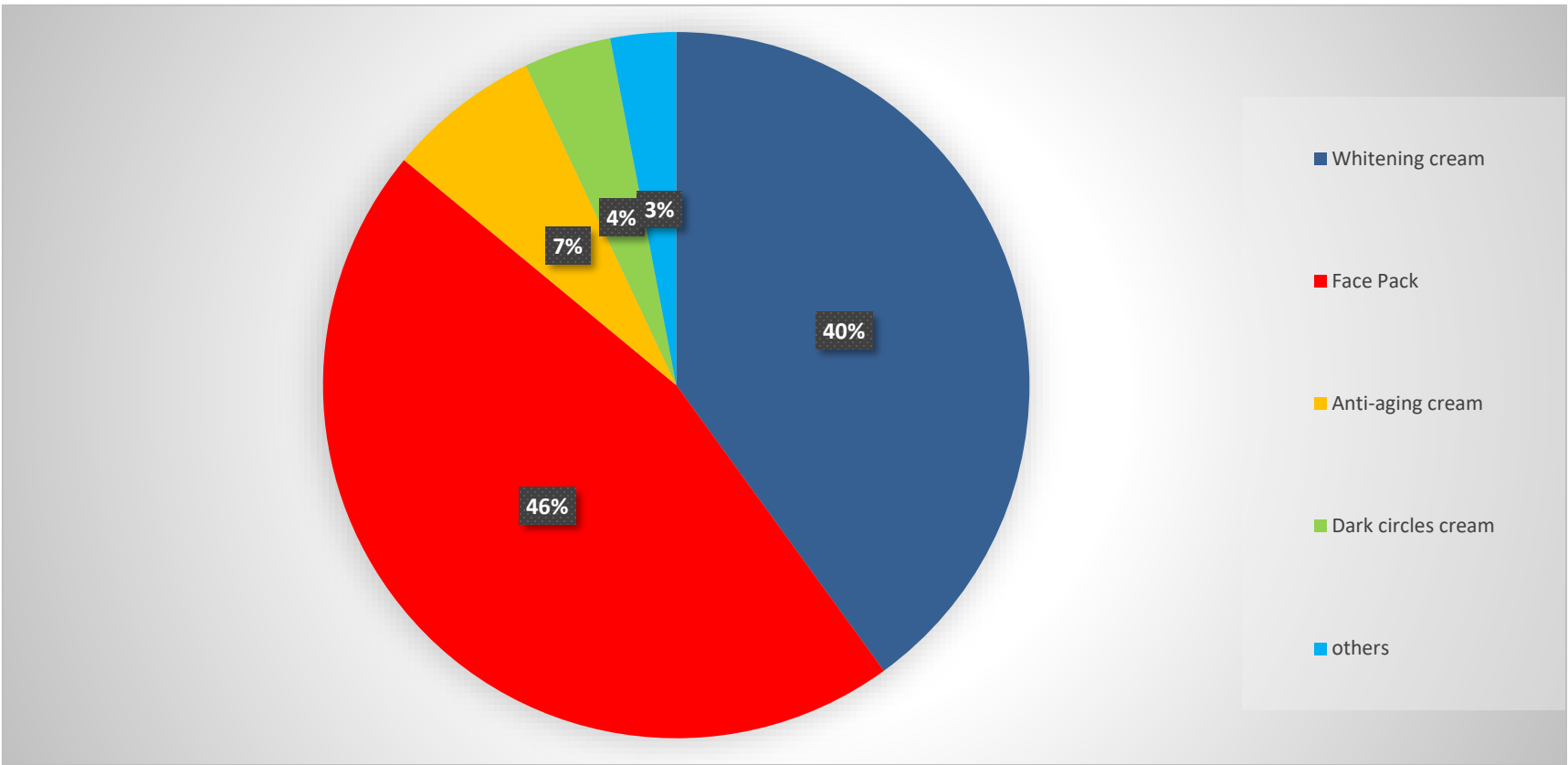
•Have you ever been deceived by any endorsement of a skincare product



INTERPRETATION:

Above table and chart, we can see that number of people who respond and majority of it. From analysis we interpret that 83% people experienced deception in skincare product and 17% people have not experienced any deception.

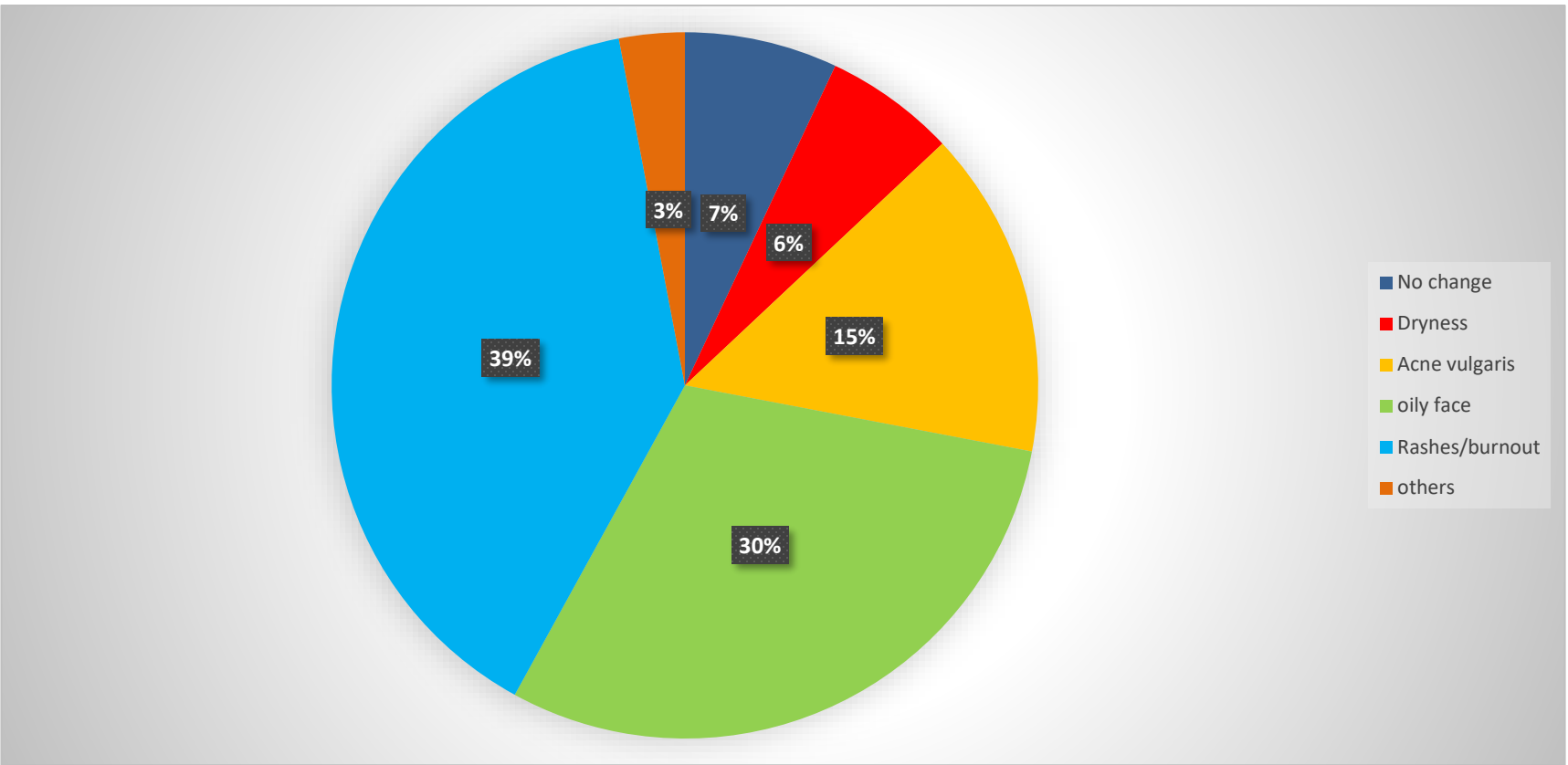
•In which type of skincare product did you experience the deception?



INTERPRETATION:

Above table and chart, we can see that number of people who respond and majority of it. From analysis we interpret that 40% people experienced deception in whitening cream, 46% people from face pack,7% people from anti-aging cream,4% people from dark circle cream and 3% people from others.

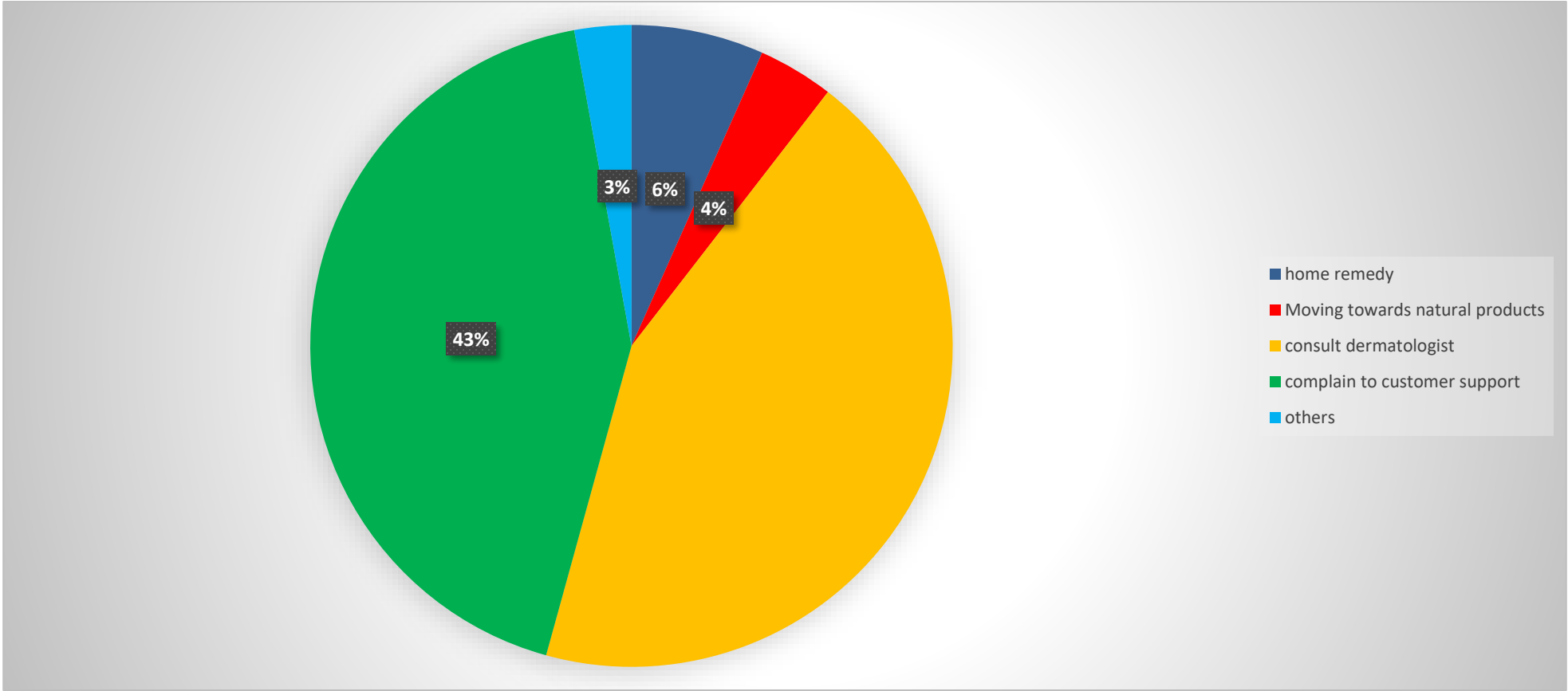
•What side effects or problems did you face?



INTERPRETATION:

Above table and chart, we can see that number of people who respond and majority of it. From analysis we interpret that 40% people experienced deception in whitening cream, 46% people from face pack,7% people from anti-aging cream,4% people from dark circle cream and 3% people from others.

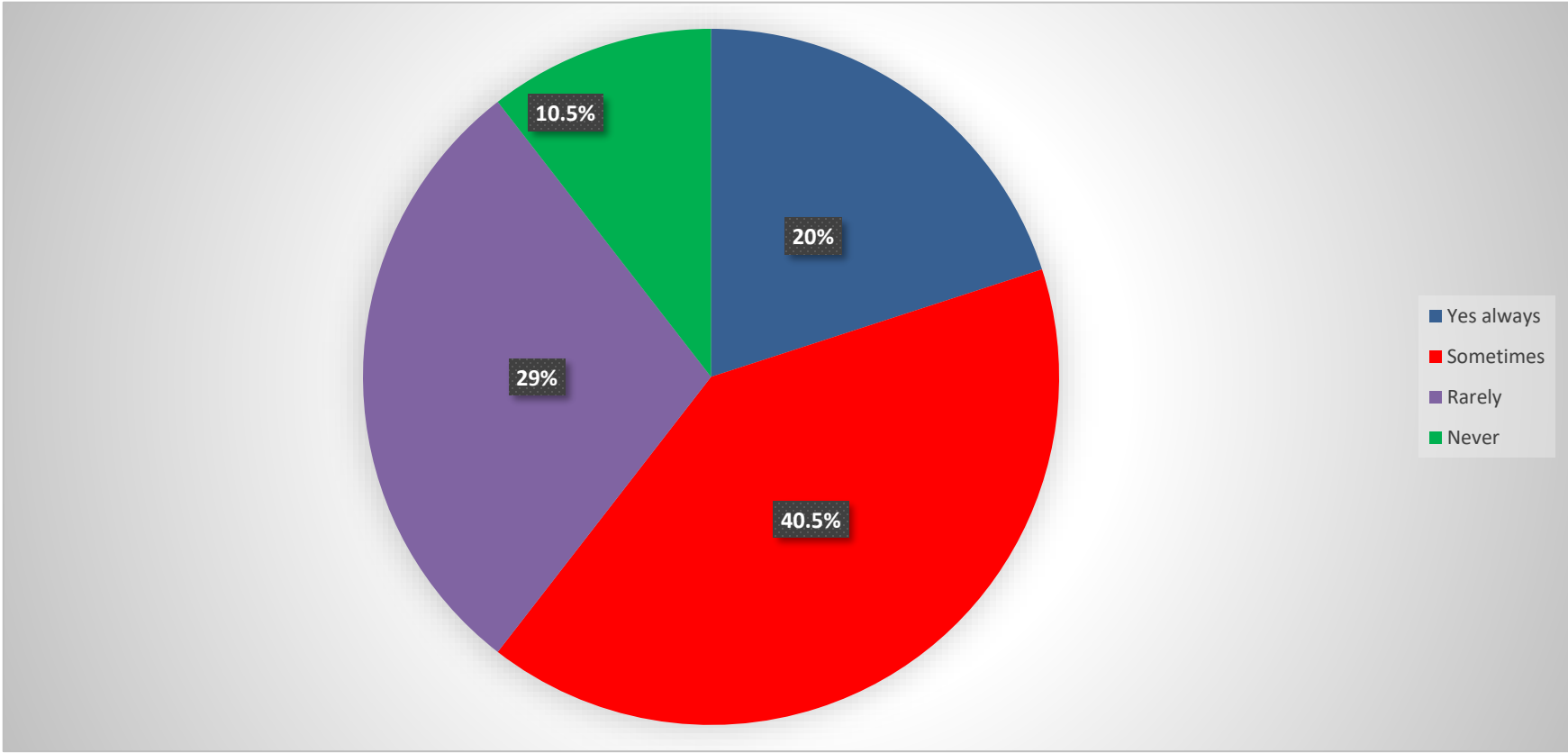
•What steps did you take after experiencing above effects or problems?



INTERPRETATION:

Above table and chart, we can see that number of people who respond and majority of it. From analysis we interpret that 7% people prefer only home remedy, 43% consult dermatologist, 2% people only move towards natural products, 45% people complain to customer support and only 3% chose other way.

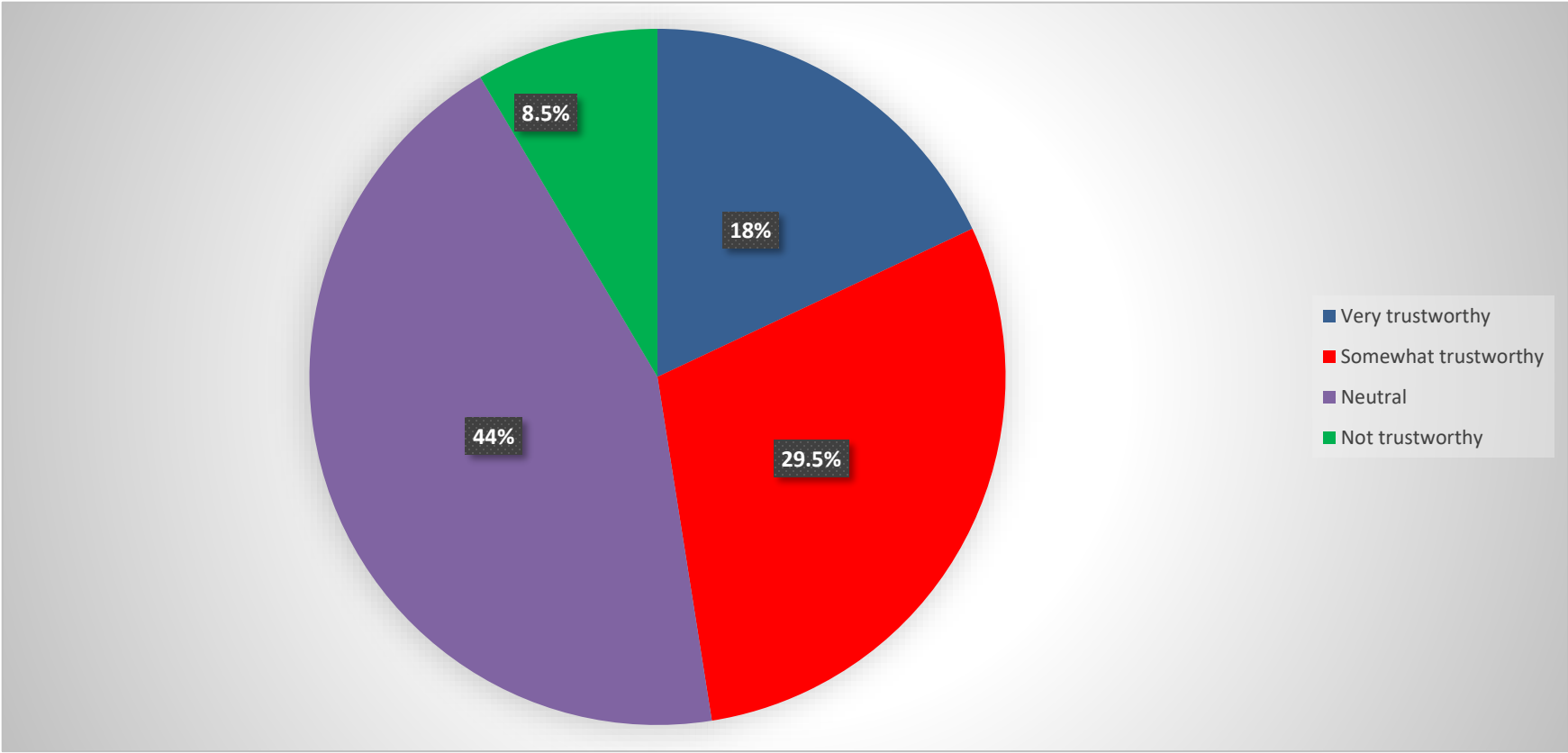
•Do you believe that influencers genuinely use the products they endorse?



INTERPRETATION:

Above table and chart, we can see that number of people who respond and majority of it. From analysis we interpret that 20% people say yes always, 40.5% people say sometimes, 29% people say rarely and 10.5% people say never.

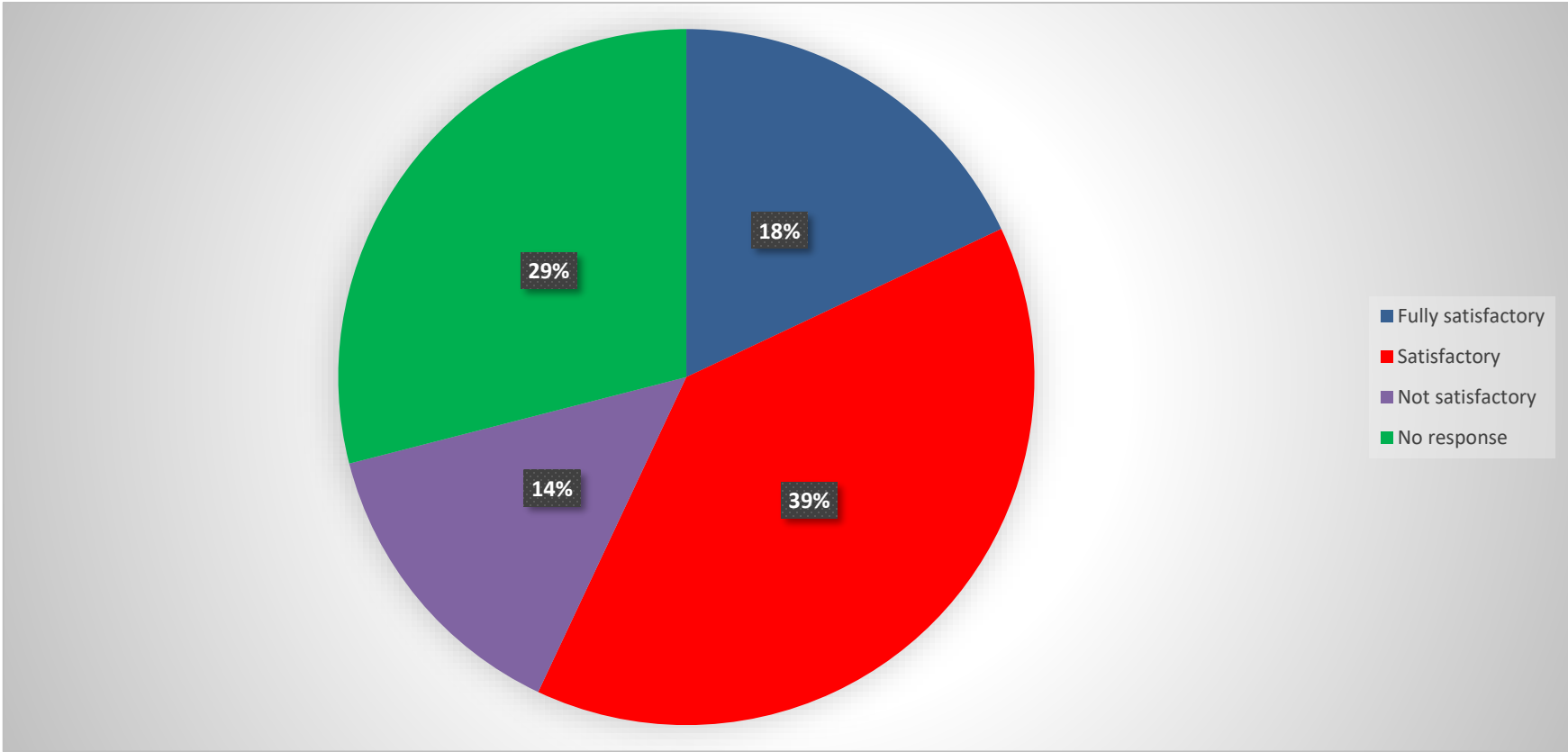
•How much do you trust endorsements from skinre influencers?



INTERPRETATION:

Above table and chart, we can see that number of people who respond and majority of it. From analysis we interpret 18% people Very trustworthy, 29.5% people Somewhat trustworthy, 44% people Neutral and 8.5% people Not trustworthy.

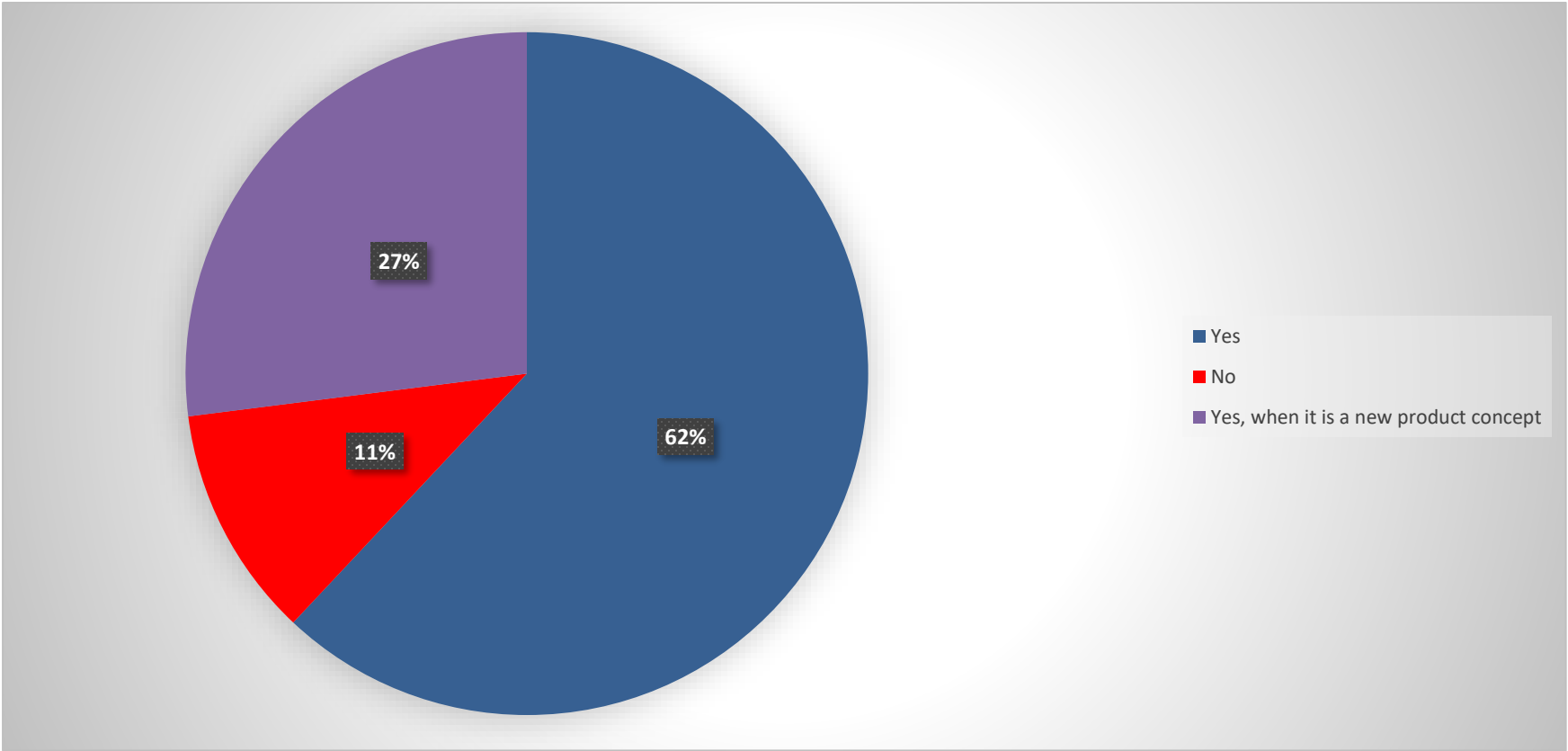
•Was the company’s response/compensation satisfactory according to you?



INTERPRETATION:

Above table and chart, we can see that number of people who respond and majority of it. From analysis we interpret that 18% people are fully satisfactory, 39% people are satisfactory, 14% people are not satisfactory and 29% people are no response.

•Do you ever check the success or efficacy of the skincare products through reviews before buying it?



INTERPRETATION:

Above table and chart, we can see that number of people who respond and majority of it. From analysis we interpret that 62% people say yes, 11% people say no and 27% people say yes, when it is a new product concept.

❏ Limitations

- The survey involved 200 women residing in Ahmedabad City and could only be considered a very small representation of the total population.
- Responses might have been subject to the influence of women participants through the motivation for participation, service availability and their pre-existing biases, and the rapport established with their interviewer.
- Some respondents were unwilling to disclose income details, investment, and spending, thereby posing potential blanks, and distorting the overall data.
- The findings may not apply to other regions, other demographic categories, or general financial trends outside Ahmedabad.
- Limited time may have influenced the completeness and depth of responses, thus producing a quality of insight up six.

❏ Findings

- This research aims to find concern of skin care problem in female youth in ahmedabad.
- Half of women are satisfied with that(Choosen brand) Skincare product
- Mostly women are buying products from their personal experience so that they can not facing more problems relating their skin
- Some women are considered dermatologist before using skincare products whereas mostly women are not considering dermatologist before using it

❑ CONCLUSION

- **In conclusion, the research on deceptive endorsement of skincare products highlights significant ethical concerns impacting female youth in Ahmedabad.**
- **The study reveals that misleading advertisements, especially those featuring influencers, often create unrealistic beauty standards and compel young women to purchase products based on false claims.**
- **This not only affects their financial resources but also contributes to issues such as low self-esteem, body image anxiety, and mental health challenges.**